



Fiery frontman: Lallianzuala Chhangte will be one of the major contributing factors in building and finishing India's attacking moves. REUTERS

Operating from the middle of the park

In a 4-2-3-1 system, a solid midfield pivot is crucial. Manolo has two solid players — Jeakson Singh Thounaojam and Lalengmawia (Apuia) Ralte — who can excel in that position. However, given the unpredictable nature of injuries, the Spanish coach may want to utilise his squad depth and not start Jeakson and Apuia together. Therefore, there is a chance that Suresh Singh Wangjam will play as one of the midfield pivots alongside Jeakson or Apuia. Additionally, Manolo has the versatile Anirudh Thapa at his disposal, whose experience will be invaluable.

In the No. 10 position, Manolo will have an excellent player in Sahal Abdul Samad, whose immaculate vision is a luxury for the forward line.

However, the Spaniard is bound to rue the absence of Brandon Fernandes as he recovers from injury. Playing under Manolo last season in FC Goa, Brandon was one of the best performers in the ISL,

LAST ISL SEASON, BRANDON FERNANDES CREATED 60 GOAL-SCORING CHANCES

creating 60 goal-scoring chances (the most in the league) and contributing to four goals. Along with his defence-splitting passes from open play, India will miss the threat Brandon brings from set-pieces with his pinpoint crossing.

Finishing the attacks

In the forward line, the choice for the two flank players should be fairly straightforward for the Indian coach, with Lallianzuala Chhangte on the right and Liston Colaco on the left. Both are pacy wingers with the ability to beat markers with their quick feet and will be two of the major contributing factors in building and finishing India's attacking moves. Mohammad Yasir, another of Manolo's players at Goa, and Naorem

Mahesh Singh can be the alternatives on the flanks.

The Spaniard's decision to omit Rahim Ali was unexpected, but his stats from last season (three goals and two assists) have not helped his case. There might have been a selection headache if Vikram Partap Singh were available. However, his injury will keep him out of the Intercontinental Cup, which indicates that Manvir Singh, who usually plays on the right flank for Mohun Bagan, will start as the No. 9 — a position that is not alien to him at all, given his off-the-ball movement, aerial prowess, and finishing ability.

Uncapped forwards Nassiri and Lalrindika are not expected to start but can get valuable minutes from the bench.